

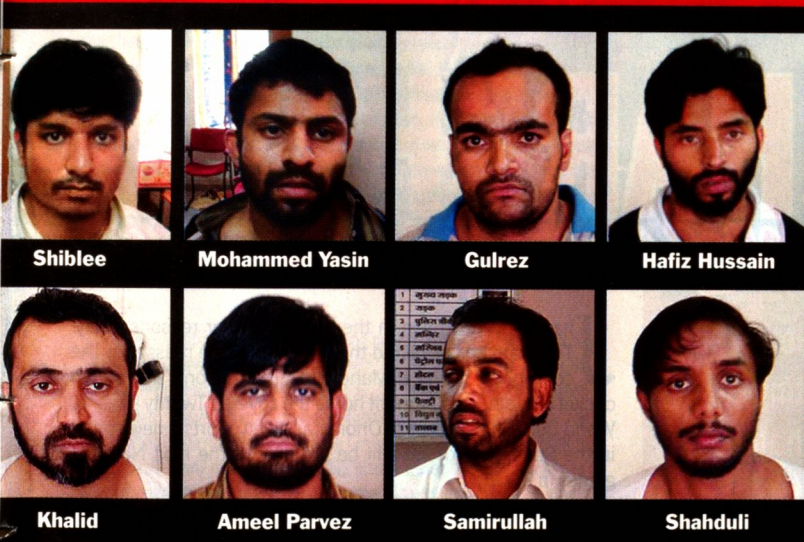
Ehtesham Siddiqui, one of the 13 SIMI cadres arrested in connection with the Mumbai serial blasts carried out in conjunction with the Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT). He is also said to have played a key role in Hyderabad blasts in 2006 and Gomti Express blasts in 2000. Investigators also hope to find vital clues into the Samjhauta Express blasts in Haryana in February 2007 as an unexploded improvised explosive device (IED) was found wrapped in an Indore newspaper and an unclaimed suitcase discovered from the site was found to be bought in

Two other important associates of Nagouri arrested in Indore are Shiblee, the South India chief and Hafiz Hussain, the Karnataka chief. The interrogators are trying to find out their links or role in the formation of such new outfits as Islamic Technical Students' Movement. These five key leaders were arrested along with eight of their associates including Mohammed Yasin, Gulrez, Ahmed Beg, Shahduli, Ansaar, Khalid, Kamraan and Samirullah. Seven pistols, 38 rounds of ammunition, large quantities of inflammatory literature,

painstaking investigation.

Police teams from six states including Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Kerala, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh have descended on Indore to get a chance to interrogate them. While Nagouri is a hardened radical and is proving to be a tough nut to crack, some of his underlings have been less resistant. Investigators offer a chilling parallel with a finishing school. "They were preparing young impressionable men for a life in terror where Pakistan based outfits and ISI could

is arguably the most important breakthrough outside J&K and reveals a sinister plot with deadly ramifications



BHASKAR PAUL

TERROR STRUCK: Mumbai serial train blast of 2006

"They were preparing for ISI to come for campus recruitment."

SURENDRA SINGH, ADDITIONAL DIRECTOR GENERAL (INTELLIGENCE), MADHYA PRADESH

Indore. In December last, Nagouri had planned attacks on American, European and Israeli tourists in Goa. He is also believed to have been planning more attacks in Bangalore, the IT hub of India in close concert with LeT. The Goa and Bangalore plans were exposed when one of the key players in the plan, Riyazuddin Nasir was arrested in Hubli in Karnataka.

Safdar's close associate Kamaruddin Nagouri is the former Madhya Pradesh chief of SIMI and a key operations man. Besides, Ameer Parvez, a resident of Unhel town in Ujjain district is linked to the Akshardham temple strike in Gandhinagar, Gujarat, in 2002.

computers, maps, nine mobile phones and disguises for changing appearances was also seized.

The police forces and intelligence agencies are in no doubt that this is their biggest catch in recent years. "If Nagouri and his band of brothers were not caught, we would have been looking at a completely indigenous, full-blown insurgency in many parts of India five years down the road," says an investigator. The arrested activists are currently in police custody at the Police Training School in Indore till April 11 but unravelling the larger conspiracy and establishing their connection to each terror strike will take months of

come for "campus recruitment", says state Additional Director General (Intelligence), Surendra Singh. The interrogations have led to the arrests of two more SIMI activists from Indore and five more in Unhel. So far, only the outline of a deadly network has started emerging. The arrests are also likely to become a major political issue with the BJP and Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan certain to make terrorism one of the main electoral planks to counter the anti-incumbency factor. Judging by the significance of the terror plot that is unravelling in Indore, countering groups led by people like Nagouri should be a more serious priority. ■